Case Study : Phishing (The Avianca Airlines Campaign, 2024-2025)

- **What the crime is**: Phishing is a type of social engineering. Attackers trick victims into giving up sensitive information, like login details or credit card numbers, by pretending to be a trusted organization.

- **How it typically happens**: In this real incident from late 2024 to early 2025, the attack unfolded in several stages:
  1. Lure Creation: Attackers duplicated the official branding and CSS of Avianca Airlines to make nearly identical "Flash Sale" graphics.
  2. Delivery: They bought harmful ads on Instagram and Facebook, focusing on users interested in travel.
  3. Exploitation: Users who clicked the ads were sent to fake domains (e.g., "https://www.google.com/search?q=avianca-refunds.com"). There, they were asked to enter their "LifeMiles" credentials and credit card information for a fake "Holiday Refund."
  4. Monetization: Stolen loyalty points were sold on the dark web, and stolen credit card data was used for unauthorized purchases.

- **Who is usually targeted:** Frequent flyers, loyalty program members, and holiday shoppers searching for travel deals on social media.

- **Consequences:**
- **Victim Impact**: Over 48,000 travelers were deceived, and 4,400 payment cards were compromised.

- **Organizational Impact:** Avianca lost about USD $6.3 million in direct losses. This amount includes service credits and a 36-hour shutdown of their call centers to reset compromised credentials.

Source: Centurio International Cyber Incident Report (July 2025).